

INFO 4602/5602
Information Visualization

“Lessons in Storytelling”

Agenda:

- “The magic of story”
- A structure for storytelling
- The narrative structure
- The power of repetition
- Tactics to ensure that your story is clear
- Group exercise/learning:
 - Continue 50-chart visualization challenge discussion

“The magic of story”

“The magic of story”

- A good story does the following:
 - **Grabs your attention**
 - **Takes you on a journey**
 - **Evokes an emotional response**
 - **After listening/watching a good story you retain the story and can describe it to a friend in the future**
- Story is a time-tested structure; humans have been communicating with stories throughout history
- We can leverage the powerful tool called story to achieve effective stakeholder communication

A structure for storytelling

A structure for storytelling

- A good story has the following structure:
 - The *beginning*
 - The *middle*
 - The *end*
- We can use this 3-part structure to set up stories we want to communicate with data to stakeholders

A structure for storytelling: **the beginning**

- The beginning introduces the **context for your audience**
- We set up the essential elements of the story – the setting, main characters, unresolved state of affairs, desired outcome – getting everyone on common ground so the story can proceed
- The beginning of a good story can/should include:
 - **The setting:** the context of your story
 - The main character/issue
 - The balance: what do your stakeholders want to see happen
 - The solution: how do you propose to bring about changes your stakeholders require?

A structure for storytelling: **the middle**

- Once you have set the stage, the bulk of your stakeholder communication should show “what could be”, with the goal of convincing your audience of the need for action
- The middle of your story is meant to **retain the attention of your audience by addressing how they can solve the problem** you introduced
- Tips to include in the middle of your story include:
 - Further develop the problem by covering relevant background (a.k.a context)
 - Incorporate external context or comparison points
 - Give examples that illustrate the issue/problem
 - Articulate what will happen if no action is taken or no change is made
 - Discuss potential options for addressing the problem, including their pros and cons
 - Illustrate the benefits of your recommended solution
 - Make it clear to your audience why they are in a unique position to make a decision or drive action

A structure for storytelling: **the end**

- Every story must have an end. **End your story with a call to action**
- Make it clear to your stakeholders **what you want them to do** with the new understanding/knowledge you have given to them
- One way to end a story is to **tie it back to the beginning**
- To wrap up your story:
 - Recap the setting (context)
 - Recap the problem – and the resulting need for action
 - Highlight any sense of urgency

The narrative structure

The narrative structure

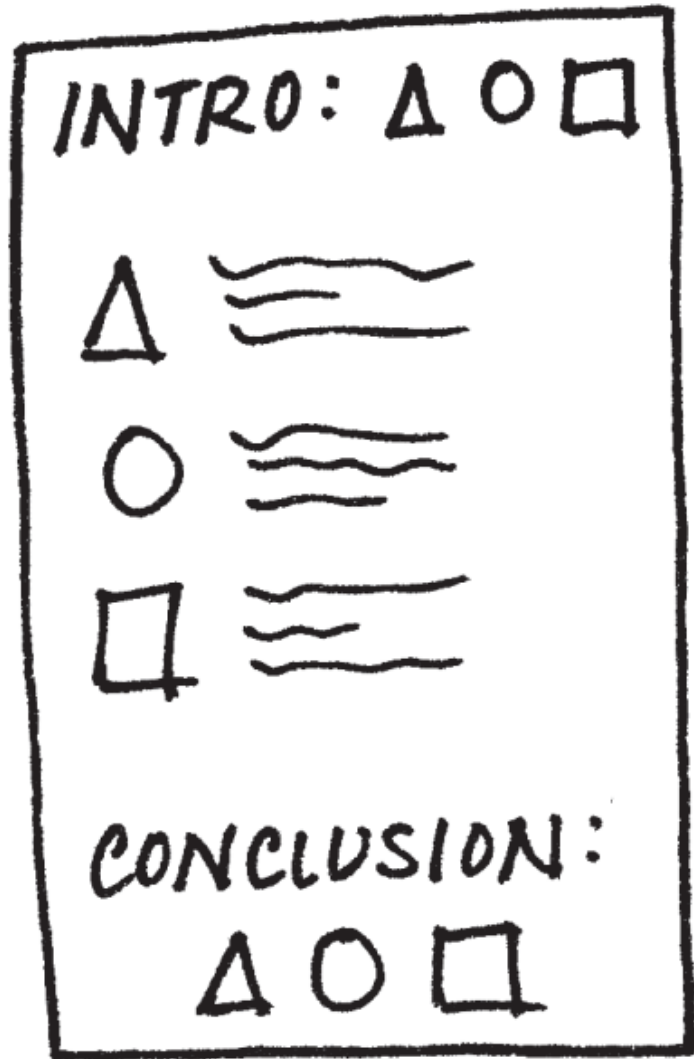
- A narrative refers to the words – written, spoken, or a combination of the two – **that tell the story in a particular order** that makes sense and convinces the audience why it is important
- A narrative is central to stakeholder communication/presentations
- “The most beautiful data visualization runs the risk of falling flat without a compelling narrative to go with it” – Knafllic (2015)
 - A skilled presenter can overcome mediocre visuals with a strong narrative
 - A strong narrative can overcome less-than-ideal visuals
- “Nirvana in communicating with data is reached **when effective visuals are combined with a powerful narrative**” – Knafllic (2015)

The narrative structure: the order of your story

- Your story **must have an order to it**. A collection of numbers, words, charts, dashboards on a given issue without structure to organize them and give them meaning is meaningless
- The narrative flow is the spoken and written path along which you take your audience over the course of your presentation or communication. This path should become clearer as you interact with your stakeholder
- Options for the order of your story include:
 - **Chronologically**: identify problem, analyze data, identify solution options and present recommendation. **Use this option if you are trying to build a reputation/credibility with your stakeholders**
 - **Lead-with-the-ending**: start with the call to action, then backup into the critical pieces of the story that support it. **Use this option if you have already established trust with your audience and they just care about the “so what”**

The power of repetition

The power of repetition



- Tell your audience what you plan to tell them
- Tell it to them
- Summarize what you just told them

Tactics to help ensure that your story is clear

- Your presentation deck (still the primary form of communicating analytical results at many companies) can benefit from the following tactics that ensure your story is clear:
 - **Horizontal logic**
 - **Vertical logic**
 - **Reverse storyboarding**
 - **Fresh perspective**

Tactic 1: Horizontal logic

- The idea behind horizontal logic is that you can read just the slide title of each slide throughout your deck and, together, these snippets tell the overarching story you want to communicate
- It is important to **have action titles (not descriptive titles) for this to work well**
- You can have an executive strategy slide upfront, with each bullet corresponding to a subsequent slide title in the same order

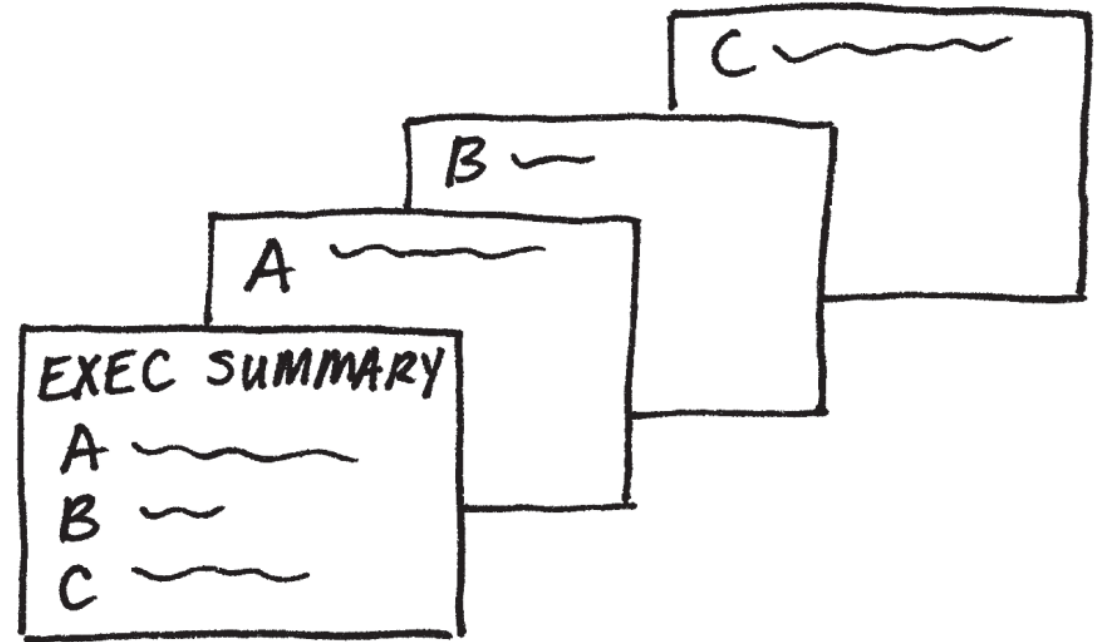


FIGURE 7.2 Horizontal logic

Tactic 2: Vertical logic

- The idea behind vertical logic is that **all information on a given slide is self-reinforcing**
 - The content reinforces the title and vice-versa
 - The words reinforce the visual and vice versa
 - There is no unrelated information on a slide

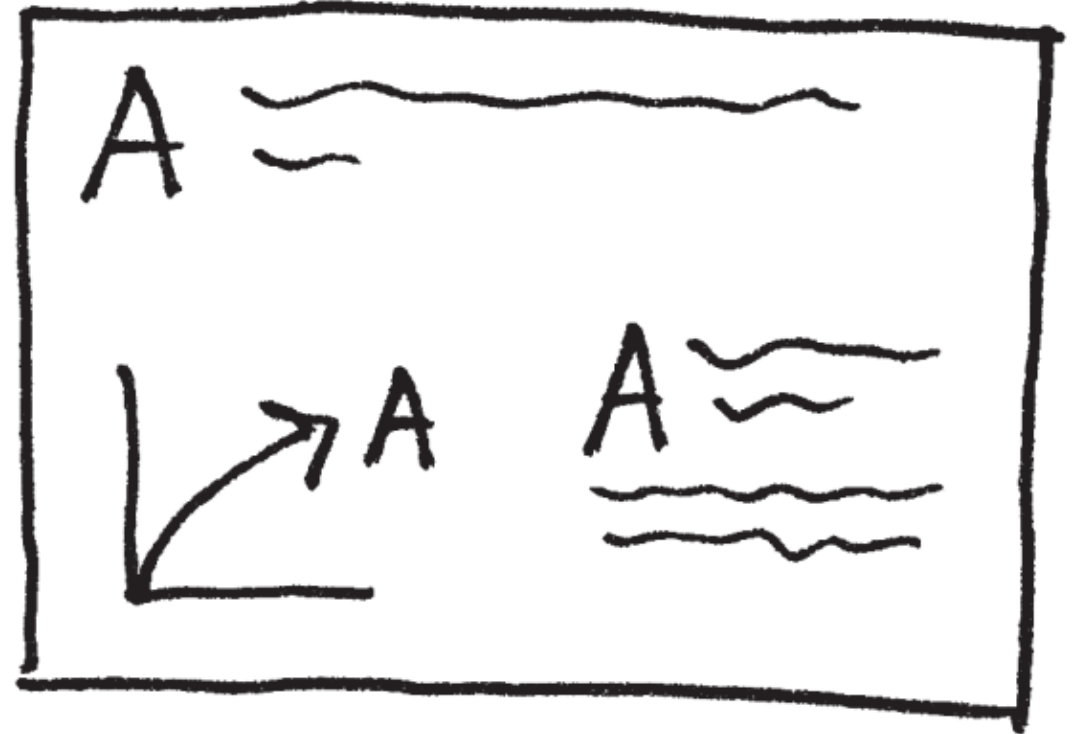


FIGURE 7.3 Vertical logic

Tactic 3: Reverse storyboarding

- With reverse storyboarding, you take the main points from each page of a final slide deck and create a single slide with the main points (at the end)

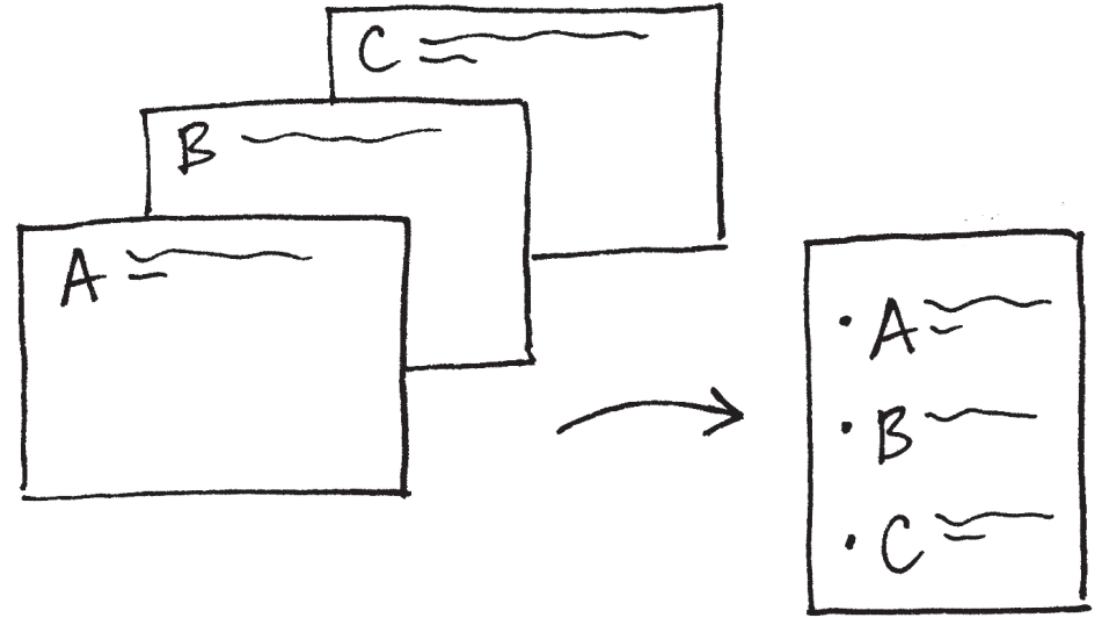


FIGURE 7.4 Reverse storyboarding



Tactic 4: A fresh perspective

- When you have crafted your communication (slides or dashboard) have your stakeholders look at it ahead of your presentation. Get insights about what to modify and what to retain
- Ask your stakeholders to **tell you what they pay attention to**, what they think is important and where they have questions
- Getting a fresh perspective will help you **understand whether the communication you designed is telling the story you mean to tell or what you need to adjust to get it right** and win the hearts and minds of your stakeholders

End of presentation